tickets, and one of them, Sanjeev Balyan, would eventually become a Union minister.

On the other side of the communal divide, it is a fact that local Muslim leaders from the Congress, SP and BSP, including the BSP MP Kadir Rana, were caught on tape delivering inflammatory speeches. Government officials who were pushing for an impartial inquiry were transferred. SP leader Azam Khan was later found in a sting operation to have asked the police to release the Muslims accused of rioting. To blame, therefore, only one community or party would be to camouflage the real tragedy of Muzaffarnagar—it represented the collective bankruptcy of a political class that was seeking votes over dead bodies.

In a way, this was the difference between the politics of religion in the early 1990s in Uttar Pradesh and what played out on the ground in 2013–14. During the Ayodhya movement, it was clear that the BJP was making an open and determined bid to stir the communal pot. Now, the communalization was more insidious. There was no blatant religious issue like the Ram mandir to incite trouble. Instead, a more silent divide was being created on the ground through a sustained whisper campaign that branded Muslims as untrustworthy and anti-national (‘*Sab ISI agents hai’*). The response was an equally worrisome radicalization of Muslims, where the moderate voices in the community had given way to the extremist rhetoric of ‘*Islam khatre mein hai*’ (Islam is in danger). Caught in the crossfire, the so-called secularists were much too enfeebled and compromised to be able to respond effectively.

Months later, I asked Shah about the allegations that he had taken political advantage of the religious polarization after the riots. His defence was, ‘*Dange humne nahi karvayen. Dange ek chhoti si ghatna se shuru huye. Agar sarkar prompt action leti, toh dange nahi hote. Yeh dange sarkar ki vote bank ki politics ki wajah se hue’* (We didn’t start the riots. Riots started with a small incident. If the government had not played vote bank politics but taken prompt action instead, there would have been no riots).